three. My mother, I was later told, had been planning to leave the ground at tea when a friend told Anjali that there was a chance I might bat after all if India lost a couple of wickets. Anjali asked my mother if she felt up to it and luckily she agreed to stay on, hoping to see me bat from the stands for the first time.

The gods must have been listening and it was a little past 3.30 p.m. when, with the score at 77–2, I walked out to the middle. The crowd was chanting 'Sachin Sachin' and the West Indians and the on-field umpires gave me a guard of honour as I walked to the pitch to take strike. I tried to soak in every moment. I was relieved to score the first run quickly. After that, I started to enjoy myself, my confidence growing with every boundary.

It was during the last over of the first day's play that my mother was shown on the stadium's giant screen for the first time. The moment she appeared the crowd gave her a standing ovation. As soon as I saw her face I got very emotional. I now had to deal with two very difficult challenges – protecting my wicket and controlling my emotions. I took my time to settle down before taking guard again.

In hindsight, I'm not sure it was such a good idea to show my mother on the screen with just one over to go for the day. The broadcasters could have shown her on television but to show her in the stadium when I was doing my best to survive the day was perhaps inappropriate. While I understand they were trying their best to make the occasion memorable, and I much appreciate them for doing so, this one thing could perhaps have been done differently. It did not stop with my mother. One after the other, they kept showing my family members on the screen, much to the delight of the huge crowd.

It all made it very difficult to concentrate and I had to keep telling myself that I needed to shut out everything that was happening around me. On this day of all days I wanted to give it my absolute best. Happily, I managed to survive the day and was unbeaten on 38. I was delighted to have stayed out there for close to an hour and a half. As I was about to leave the park, I raised my bat towards my family.

When I look back at these moments they feel surreal, to say the least. My mother's reaction when she first saw herself on the giant screen, her tongue coming out in embarrassment because she wasn't used to the limelight, was so natural that I had tears in my eyes. The crowd standing up to acknowledge her was more than I could have asked for as a son